

Chapter 1 — The French Revolution

The one-line point: A **bankrupt king** called a meeting he had not called in **175 years**, to make the only group already paying tax pay more. That meeting asked a question nobody could put back in the box — **who does the nation actually belong to?** The words we now use for politics — *citizen, nation, rights, liberty, equality* — were forged in the five years that followed.

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → World History (<i>not</i> Indian History)
Sub-discipline	Political revolution · history of ideas · the making of the modern state
Period	1774 – 1815 (core: 1789–1794)
Prelims (GS Paper I)	★ ★ Rarely asked directly, but the Declaration of Rights , the estates , Napoleon and the abolition of slavery are all fair game as one-liners
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ ★ World History is explicitly in the syllabus — " <i>events from 18th century... political philosophies... their forms and effect on the society.</i> " The French Revolution is the starting gun for all of it
Also feeds	Polity ★ ★ ★ (separation of powers, natural rights, sovereignty of the people — the vocabulary of our own Constitution), Essay ★ ★ ★ (liberty vs equality; means vs ends; revolution and its children), Ethics ★ ★ (Robespierre's "terror is justice" — a case study in ends justifying means), IR ★ (nationalism, self-determination)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ ★ — one of the two or three most quotable chapters in the whole NCERT History series
Overlaps with	Class 10 Ch.1 (nationalism in Europe picks up exactly where this ends), Class 11 Themes in World History , Class 8 Ch.8 (the ideas that reached Indian nationalists)

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Draw** the society of estates and say **exactly who paid what tax to whom**. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain the fiscal crisis** — where the debt came from and why raising taxes could not fix it. ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe a subsistence crisis** as a chain of cause and effect. ★ ★
- ☐ **Name the four philosophers** and the one core idea each contributed. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain the voting dispute** in the Estates-General and why it was the real trigger. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Sequence** 5 May → 20 June → 14 July → 4 August 1789. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **State what the Constitution of 1791 did** — and who it left out. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Quote** at least three articles of the **Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen**. ★ ★
- ☐ **Read the political symbols** — broken chain, fasces, eye in triangle, Phrygian cap. ★
- ☐ **Distinguish** Jacobins, *sans-culottes*, the Convention and the Directory. ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain the Reign of Terror** and state Robespierre's own justification for it. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Answer "Did women have a revolution?"** with evidence on both sides. ★ ★ ★

- ☐ **Narrate the abolition of slavery** — 1794, reintroduced, 1848. ★★
- ☐ **Explain the rise of Napoleon** as a *consequence* of the Directory, not an accident. ★★
- ☐ **List the contradictions** in the message of universal rights. ★★

Start Here: 14 July 1789

Paris wakes up frightened. The king has ordered troops into the city and the rumour is that he means to fire on his own people.

MORNING	7,000 men and women gather at the town hall. They decide to form a people's MILITIA. They break into government buildings looking for arms.
AFTERNOON	Several hundred march east to the BASTILLE, the fortress-prison, hoping for hoarded ammunition. The commander is killed. The prisoners are released. There are SEVEN of them.
AFTER	The fortress is demolished. Its stones are sold in the markets as souvenirs.

★ **Read that "seven" carefully — it is the whole point.** The Bastille held almost no one. It was stormed because *"it stood for the despotic power of the king."* This is the first thing to understand about the Revolution: **it was fought over symbols and meanings as much as over bread and taxes.**

⚠ **And NCERT's honest caveat, which is very quotable:** historians later saw 14 July as the beginning of a chain of events ending in the king's execution — **"though most people at the time did not anticipate this outcome."** Nobody storming the Bastille was planning to behead Louis XVI. Revolutions are read backwards; they are not lived that way.

1 French Society Before 1789 — The Old Regime

The society of estates

1st ESTATE — THE CLERGY privileged by BIRTH · pays NO tax to the state COLLECTS the tithe (1/10 of agricultural produce)
2nd ESTATE — THE NOBILITY privileged by BIRTH · pays NO tax to the state COLLECTS feudal dues + forced labour from peasants
3rd ESTATE — EVERYBODY ELSE RICH: big businessmen, merchants, court officials, lawyers POOR: peasants and artisans POOREST: small peasants, landless labour, servants PAYS: the tithe (to Church) feudal dues + labour service (to nobles) the TAILLE — direct tax (to the state) indirect taxes on salt, tobacco (to the state)

★ ★ ★ **The single sentence to remember:** "The burden of financing activities of the state through taxes was borne by the third estate alone."

The numbers that make it worse:

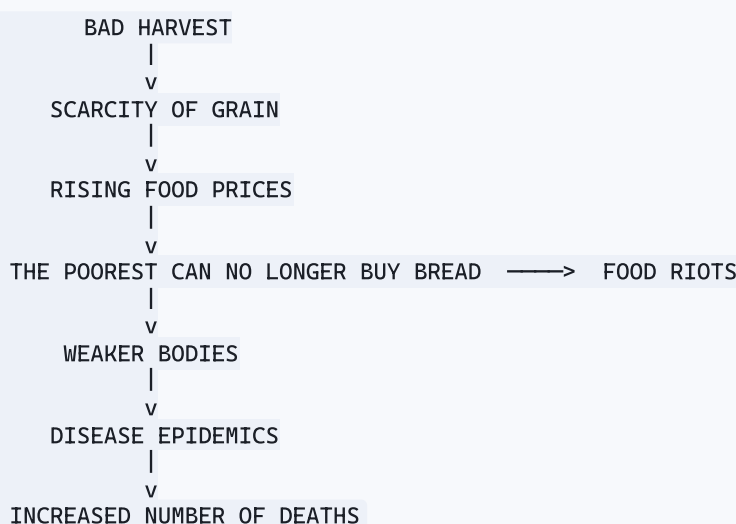
Fact	Figure
Peasants as share of population	about 90%
Land actually owned by peasants	only a small number owned what they cultivated
Land owned by nobles + Church + rich third estate	about 60%
Population 1715 → 1789	23 million → 28 million

The word to know: *Old Regime (Ancien Régime)* = **the society and institutions of France before 1789**. The society of estates was part of the **feudal system dating back to the middle ages**.

NCERT's own image for the relationship is an anonymous etching called *The Spider and the Fly*: "The nobleman is the spider, the peasant the fly." The peasant brings grain, fruit, money, salad; the fat lord "does not even care to grace him with a look."

📦 1.1 The struggle to survive — a subsistence crisis

This is a **chain**, and NCERT explicitly asks you to fill in the chain, so learn it as a chain:



Why it kept happening under the Old Regime:

- Population rose **23 → 28 million** ⇒ demand for foodgrain rose.
- Grain **production could not keep pace** ⇒ price of **bread**, the staple diet, rose rapidly.
- **Wages were fixed by workshop owners** and did **not** keep pace with prices.
- ⇒ "the gap between the poor and the rich widened", and any drought or hail tipped it into crisis.

Definition to memorise: ★ **Subsistence crisis** — **an extreme situation where the basic means of livelihood are endangered.**

💡 1.3 The middle class asks a new question

Peasants and workers had revolted before — over taxes, over food. **They had always failed.** NCERT's explanation is precise and worth quoting:

"They lacked the means and programmes to carry out full-scale measures that would bring about a change in the social and economic order."

★ ★ **That is the analytical point: anger is not a programme.** What changed in the eighteenth century was the arrival of a group that had **both** grievance **and** a programme — the **middle class**.

Who they were and where their money came from:

- Merchants and manufacturers grown rich on **expanding overseas trade** and on **manufacture of woollen and silk textiles**.
- Plus professions — **lawyers, administrative officials**.
- All **educated**.

Their one belief, which is the seed of everything that follows:

★ ★ ★ *"No group in society should be privileged by birth. Rather, a person's social position must depend on his **merit**."*

🗨️ The four philosophers — learn one line each

Thinker	Work	The idea
John Locke	<i>Two Treatises of Government</i>	Refuted the doctrine of the divine and absolute right of the monarch
Jean Jacques Rousseau	<i>The Social Contract</i>	Government based on a social contract between people and their representatives; one person, one vote
Montesquieu	<i>The Spirit of the Laws</i>	Division of power between legislature, executive, judiciary
(the working example)	The American Constitution	Montesquieu's model put into force in the USA after the thirteen colonies' independence; its guarantee of individual rights was an important example for French thinkers

★ ★ ★ **Note the direct line to your Polity syllabus.** Separation of powers, natural rights, popular sovereignty, social contract — you will meet all four again in Laxmikanth. They enter modern politics *here*.

🗨️ How ideas travelled without mass literacy

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SALONS + COFFEE-HOUSES -> intensive discussion
      |
BOOKS + NEWSPAPERS -> and crucially,
      |
READ ALOUD IN GROUPS -> "for the benefit of those who
                        could not read and write"
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Remember this mechanism. It answers the obvious objection — *how does political philosophy reach people who cannot read?* You will see the same mechanism again in the Indian national movement.

🗨️ The lived grievance — Danton's letter (Source A)

Georges Danton, later a revolutionary, on finishing his studies:

*"The choice of a career in the army was not open to me **as I was not a noble by birth**, nor did I have a patron. The church too could not offer me a refuge. I could not buy an office as I did not possess a sou... **the system had provided us with an education without however offering a field where our talents could be utilised.**"*

★ ★ This is the **educated-and-blocked** grievance, and it is the most dangerous kind a society can generate. Keep it — it is directly transferable to essays and to the Indian middle class of the 1880s in **Class 8 Ch.8**.

2 The Outbreak — 1789 in Four Dates

🏠 A way to see the voting dispute clearly

Picture a housing society with **three blocks**. Block A has 300 flats, Block B has 300, Block C has 600. **Only Block C pays maintenance**. The society's rule is **one vote per block** — so A and B, who pay nothing, can always outvote C two-to-one and raise C's maintenance again.

Now C says: *stop counting blocks, count flats*. That single procedural demand would flip every future decision. **That is the Estates-General of 1789**, and it is why a dispute over voting procedure — not a battle — is the actual hinge of the Revolution.

📅 The sequence

1614	last meeting of the Estates-General
(175 YEARS of not asking anyone)	
5 MAY 1789	ESTATES-GENERAL convened at Versailles 1st estate: 300 reps } seated in rows 2nd estate: 300 reps } facing each other 3rd estate: 600 reps -> MADE TO STAND AT THE BACK Peasants, artisans and WOMEN: denied entry (but 40,000 letters of grievances were carried in) DISPUTE: one vote per ESTATE (king) vs one vote per MEMBER (third estate) King refuses. Third estate WALKS OUT.
20 JUNE 1789	THE TENNIS COURT OATH They assemble in an indoor tennis court at Versailles, declare themselves a NATIONAL ASSEMBLY, and swear not to disperse till they have drafted a CONSTITUTION limiting the powers of the monarch. Led by MIRABEAU and ABBE SIEYES.
14 JULY 1789	THE STORMING OF THE BASTILLE (bad harvest + bakers hoarding + women storming bakeries + troops ordered into Paris)
JULY-AUG	THE GREAT FEAR in the countryside Rumour: lords have hired brigands to destroy the ripe crops. Peasants seize hoes and pitchforks, attack CHATEAUX, loot hoarded grain, and BURN THE DOCUMENTS RECORDING MANORIAL DUES. Nobles flee abroad.
4 AUGUST 1789 (night)	THE ASSEMBLY'S DECREE - feudal system of obligations and taxes ABOLISHED - clergy forced to give up privileges - TITHES abolished - CHURCH LANDS CONFISCATED -> government gains assets worth 2 BILLION LIVRES

★ ★ ★ Two people worth knowing by name:

- **Mirabeau** — *born into a noble family* but convinced feudal privilege must go; brought out a journal and gave powerful speeches to the Versailles crowds.
- **Abbé Sieyès** — *originally a priest*; wrote the pamphlet "**What is the Third Estate?**"

 **The exam-friendly irony:** the two men who led the third estate's revolt came **from the first and second estates**. Privilege was not overthrown only from below.

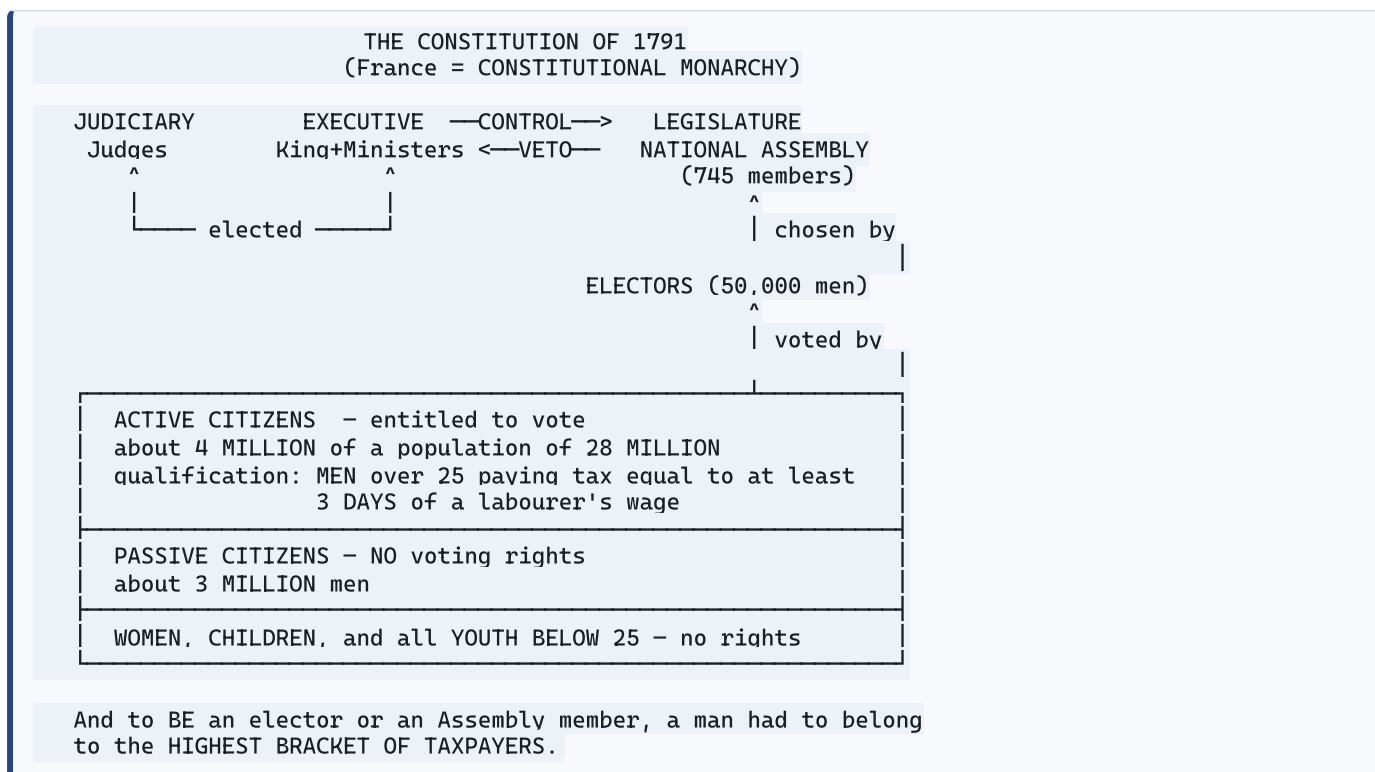
Why the king had no choice

Cause	Detail
Inherited an empty treasury	Louis XVI acceded in 1774 , aged 20 , married to the Austrian princess Marie Antoinette
Long years of war	had already drained French finances
The court at Versailles	maintaining an " <i>extravagant court at the immense palace</i> "
The American War	France helped the thirteen American colonies against Britain — added over 1 billion livres to a debt already above 2 billion livres
The debt trap	lenders now charged 10% interest ; an " <i>increasing percentage of its budget on interest payments alone</i> "
The only fix available	raise taxes — " <i>Yet even this measure would not have sufficed</i> "

☆☆ **The deep structural point for essays:** France's monarchy was destroyed partly by the **debt it took on to help create the American republic**. Empires that fund other people's freedom often cannot afford their own arrangements afterwards.

3 The Constitution of 1791 — and Its Fine Print

How the new machine worked



☆☆☆ **This diagram is the single most examinable thing in the chapter.** Everything that happens next — the Jacobins, the Terror, the women's clubs — is a fight over **who is inside that top box**.

⚠️ **Note the sleight of hand.** The Assembly was **indirectly elected**: citizens voted for **electors**, who chose the Assembly. Only 4 million of 28 million could vote at all, and only the richest could *be* elected. A revolution against privilege of **birth** immediately installed privilege of **wealth**.

📖 The Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen

The Constitution **began** with it. Rights such as **the right to life, freedom of speech, freedom of opinion, equality before law** were declared "**natural and inalienable**" — *they belonged to each human being by birth and could not be taken away*, and **it was the duty of the state to protect them**.

The articles worth being able to quote:

Art.	Text (compressed)
1	"Men are born and remain free and equal in rights ."
2	The aim of every political association is the preservation of natural and inalienable rights — liberty, property, security and resistance to oppression
3	★ ★ ★ "The source of all sovereignty resides in the nation ; no group or individual may exercise authority that does not come from the people."
4	" Liberty consists of the power to do whatever is not injurious to others ."
6	*"Law is the expression of the general will."* All citizens may participate in its formation; all are equal before it
7	No one may be accused, arrested or detained except in cases determined by law
11	Every citizen may speak, write and print freely — taking responsibility for abuse
12	A common tax is indispensable; it must be assessed equally on all citizens in proportion to their means
17	★ " Property is a sacred and inviolable right " — no one may be deprived of it unless legally established public necessity requires it, with just compensation given in advance

🔗 **Polity link worth making now:** Article 4's definition of liberty ("*whatever is not injurious to others*") is the ancestor of **reasonable restrictions** under **Art. 19(2)** of the Indian Constitution. Article 3 is the ancestor of "*We, the People*." Article 17 is the ancestor of the **right to property** fight in India — and note that **India eventually demoted property from a fundamental right, while France declared it "sacred and inviolable."**

🎨 Box 1 — Reading political symbols

Most people could not read, so **images did the work of arguments**. Learn these; they turn up in Class 10 as well.

Symbol	Meaning
Broken chain	Chains fettered slaves — a broken chain = the act of becoming free
Bundle of rods / <i>fascis</i>	One rod breaks easily, a bundle does not — strength lies in unity (fraternity)
The eye within a triangle radiating light	The all-seeing eye = knowledge ; the sun's rays drive away the clouds of ignorance
Sceptre	Royal power
Snake biting its tail (a ring)	Eternity — a ring has neither beginning nor end
Red Phrygian cap	The cap worn by a slave upon becoming free — liberty
Blue–white–red	The national colours of France
The winged woman	Personification of the law
The Law Tablet	The law is the same for all ; all are equal before it

⚠ **Gender detail that is easy to miss and often asked:** *sans-culottes* men wore the red liberty cap. "Women however were not allowed to do so." The symbol of liberty itself was gendered.

🗨 Marat's warning (Source B)

The journalist **Jean-Paul Marat**, in *L'Ami du peuple* (*The Friend of the People*), on the 1791 Constitution:

*"The task of representing the people has been given to the rich... the lot of the poor and oppressed will never be improved by peaceful means alone... when they have managed to cast off the yoke of the aristocrats, **they will do the same to the other owners of wealth.**"*

★ ★ ★ **Marat is predicting Chapter 2 of this book.** The demand that political equality be followed by **economic** equality is exactly where socialism begins. Mark this passage — it is the bridge between the two chapters.

4 From Monarchy to Republic — 1792

⚔ The war that radicalised everything

Louis XVI signs the Constitution ... and secretly negotiates with the KING OF PRUSSIA.

Neighbouring rulers plan to send troops to crush the revolution.

APRIL 1792 – the National Assembly strikes FIRST: declares war on PRUSSIA and AUSTRIA.

Volunteers throng from the provinces. They see it as "a war of the PEOPLE against KINGS and ARISTOCRACIES all over Europe."

They sing the MARSEILLAISE, composed by ROGET DE L'ISLE, first sung by volunteers from MARSEILLES marching into Paris. → now the NATIONAL ANTHEM OF FRANCE.

What the war did at home: losses and economic hardship; **men away at the front, women left to earn a living and run families;** and a growing conviction that "*the revolution had to be carried further, as the Constitution of 1791 gave political rights only to the richer sections of society.*"

Jacobins and *sans-culottes*

Name from	the former convent of St Jacob in Paris
Who	"the less prosperous sections" — small shopkeepers; artisans such as shoemakers, pastry cooks, watch-makers, printers; servants and daily-wage workers
Leader	Maximilian Robespierre
The trousers	They wore long striped trousers like dock workers, to set themselves apart from nobles who wore knee breeches
★ The name	<i>sans-culottes</i> = "those without knee breeches"
Plus	the men wore the red cap symbolising liberty (women were not allowed to)

 **Prelims-style trap:** *sans-culottes* does **not** mean "without trousers." It means **without knee breeches** — a deliberate class statement made through clothing. NCERT devotes a whole later chapter (*Clothing: A Social History*, now removed) to exactly this idea.

The Republic

SUMMER 1792	Jacobins plan an insurrection of Parisians angered by short supplies and high food prices.
10 AUGUST 1792	They storm the PALACE OF THE TUILERIES, massacre the king's guards, hold the king hostage for several hours. The Assembly votes to imprison the royal family.
	ELECTIONS HELD — and now ALL MEN OF 21 AND ABOVE, REGARDLESS OF WEALTH, GET THE VOTE. (the property qualification is gone)
21 SEPT 1792	The new assembly — the CONVENTION — ABOLISHES THE MONARCHY and declares FRANCE A REPUBLIC.
21 JAN 1793	Louis XVI, sentenced to death for TREASON, is executed publicly at the PLACE DE LA CONCORDE. Marie Antoinette meets the same fate shortly after.

Definitions: Republic = a form of government where **the people elect the government including the head of government; there is no hereditary monarchy.** **Treason** = betrayal of one's country or government.

5 The Reign of Terror, 1793–94

What Robespierre did

Domain	Measure
Politics	"A policy of severe control and punishment." Anyone he saw as an enemy of the republic — ex-nobles and clergy, members of other political parties, even members of his own party who disagreed with his methods — was arrested, imprisoned, tried by a revolutionary tribunal , and if 'guilty', guillotined
The instrument	The guillotine — two poles and a blade — named after Dr Guillotin who invented it
Wages and prices	Laws placing a maximum ceiling on wages and prices
Food	Meat and bread rationed ; peasants forced to transport grain to the cities and sell at government-fixed prices
Bread itself	White flour forbidden ; all citizens required to eat pain d'égalité (equality bread), a loaf of wholewheat
Speech	<i>Monsieur</i> and <i>Madame</i> abolished — everyone became Citoyen and Citoyenne (Citizen)
Religion	Churches shut down , buildings converted into barracks or offices
The end	He pursued his policies "so relentlessly that even his supporters began to demand moderation." Convicted July 1794, arrested, guillotined the next day.

The debate you should be able to argue both sides of

This is **Ethics and Essay material of the highest quality**. Learn both quotations.

ROBESPIERRE, to the Convention, 7 February 1794: *"To establish and consolidate democracy... we must first finish the war of liberty against tyranny... We must **annihilate the enemies of the republic** at home and abroad, or else we shall perish. **In time of Revolution a democratic government may rely on terror. Terror is nothing but justice, swift, severe and inflexible.**"**

CAMILLE DESMOULINS, 1793 — *executed shortly after, during the Terror*: *"Some people believe that Liberty is like a child, which needs to go through a phase of being disciplined before it attains maturity. **Quite the opposite. Liberty is Happiness, Reason, Equality, Justice, it is the Declaration of Rights...** Would it be possible to bring a single person to the scaffold **without making ten more enemies among his relations and friends?**"**

ROBESPIERRE
Liberty is a DESTINATION.
Get there by any means,
including terror.
Terror = justice.

DESMOULINS
Liberty is the ROAD ITSELF.
The means ARE the end; violence
only manufactures more enemies.
Terror = the opposite of the
Declaration of Rights.

★★★★ **The killer detail for an essay:** Desmoulins was **guillotined for saying this**. The argument was not settled by reason; it was settled by the blade — which is itself Desmoulins' argument proved.

*"Through all these changes in the form of government, the ideals of **freedom, of equality before the law and of fraternity** remained inspiring ideals that motivated political movements in France and the rest of Europe during the following century."*

6

NCERT asks this as a question, not a statement. Answer it as one — with a ledger.

- Most third-estate women **had to work for a living**: seamstresses, laundresses, sellers of flowers/fruit/vegetables, **domestic servants**.
- Most had **no access to education or job training**. Only **daughters of nobles or wealthier third-estate families** could study at a convent — after which **their families arranged a marriage**.
- They also had to **cook, fetch water, queue up for bread, look after children**.
- ★ **Their wages were lower than those of men.**

👉 What they did

Action	Detail
5 October 1789	Parisian women marched to Versailles and brought the king back with them to Paris
Clubs	About sixty women's clubs across French cities
The famous one	★ The Society of Revolutionary and Republican Women
Newspapers	They started their own
The demand	The same political rights as men — the right to vote , to be elected to the Assembly , and to hold political office
The grievance	The Constitution of 1791 reduced them to passive citizens

+ What they actually won (the early years)

- **State schools created; schooling made compulsory for all girls.**
- **Fathers could no longer force them into marriage against their will.**
- **Marriage made a contract** entered into **freely** and **registered under civil law**.
- ★ **Divorce made legal** — and could be applied for by both women and men.
- **Women could train for jobs, become artists, or run small businesses.**

— What was then taken back

★★★ *"During the **Reign of Terror**, the new government issued laws ordering **closure of women's clubs** and **banning their political activities**. Many prominent women were **arrested** and a number of them **executed**."*

👤 Olympe de Gouges (1748–1793)

Who	"One of the most important of the politically active women in revolutionary France"
Her protest	Against the Constitution and the Declaration of Rights of Man and Citizen, because they excluded women from basic rights that each human being was entitled to
Her document, 1791	★★★ The Declaration of the Rights of Woman and Citizen , addressed to the Queen and the members of the National Assembly , demanding that they act on it
1793	She criticised the Jacobin government for forcibly closing women's clubs
The end	Tried by the National Convention , charged with treason , and executed

Her rewriting of the Declaration — the method is the message:

1. ***"Woman is born free and remains equal to man in rights."***
2. *"The source of all sovereignty resides in the nation, which is nothing but **the union of woman and man**."*
3. *"All **female and male** citizens should have a say... **All female and male citizens are equally entitled to all honours and public employment according to their abilities** and without any other distinction than that of their talents."*
4. *"**No woman is an exception**... Women, like men, obey this rigorous law."*

★★★★ **Why this is such a powerful exam example:** she did not write a new manifesto. She took the revolution's *own* sacred text and **inserted women into it**, sentence by sentence. That is the sharpest possible

way to expose an exclusion — you show that the principle was already universal and the practice was not.

🌸 The opposing argument — Chaumette (Source G), 1793

The Jacobin politician justifying the closure of women's clubs:

"Has Nature entrusted domestic duties to men? Has she given us breasts to nurture babies? **No**. She said to Man: Be a man. **Hunting, agriculture, political duties... that is your kingdom**. She said to Woman: Be a woman... **the things of the household, the sweet duties of motherhood** — those are your tasks. **Shameless are those women, who wish to become men.**"*

★ ★ **Note the structure of the argument: it appeals to *nature* to settle a question of *rights*.** That move — dressing a social arrangement as a biological fact — is the standard form of every argument against extending rights, and you will meet it again in **Class 8 Ch.7** on widow remarriage and women's education in India.

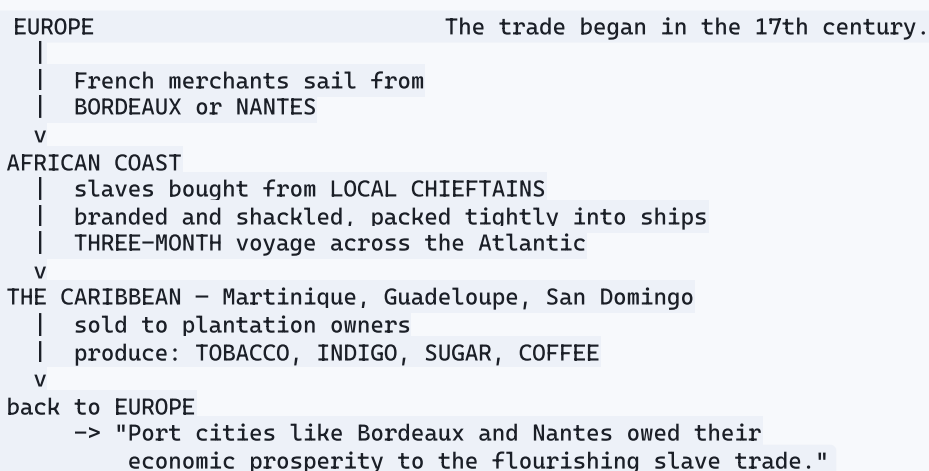
🕒 The long tail

- Women's movements for **voting rights and equal wages** continued **for the next two hundred years** in many countries.
- The fight for the vote ran through **an international suffrage movement** in the **late 19th and early 20th centuries**.
- ★ ★ ★ **Women in France finally won the right to vote in 1946 — 157 years after 1789.**

🎯 **How to answer "Did women have a revolution?"** — *Partly, and temporarily*. They **made** the revolution (October 1789, the clubs, the newspapers), they **won real civil gains** (divorce, schooling, marriage as contract, training for jobs), they **were denied political rights throughout** (passive citizens in 1791; still excluded when the vote was widened to all men in 1792), and they were **actively suppressed** in 1793. The revolution gave women a **language** for their claim long before it gave them the claim.

7 The Abolition of Slavery

🚢 The triangular trade



Why slavery existed at all, in NCERT's own causal terms: Europeans were **reluctant to go and work in distant and unfamiliar lands** ⇒ **shortage of labour on the plantations** ⇒ met by the **triangular slave**

trade. The exploitation of slave labour *"made it possible to meet the growing demand in European markets for sugar, coffee and indigo."*

88 The sequence — and the u-turn

18th c.	"Throughout the eighteenth century there was LITTLE CRITICISM OF SLAVERY IN FRANCE."
1789-93	The National Assembly holds LONG DEBATES on whether the rights of man extend to all French subjects INCLUDING THOSE IN THE COLONIES. It passes NO LAW – "fearing opposition from businessmen whose incomes depended on the slave trade."
1794	THE CONVENTION legislates to FREE ALL SLAVES in the French overseas possessions. (NCERT: "one of the most revolutionary social reforms of the JACOBIN regime")
1804	NAPOLÉON REINTRODUCES SLAVERY. "Plantation owners understood their freedom as including the RIGHT TO ENSLAVE African Negroes in pursuit of their economic interests."
1848	Slavery FINALLY abolished in French colonies.

★★★★ The sentence to carry into an essay: *plantation owners understood **their** freedom as including the right to enslave others.* That is the contradiction of universal rights in one line — **freedom claimed as a property right over other people.** If you write one thing about this chapter, write this.

Word to know: Emancipation — the act of freeing.

8 The Revolution in Everyday Life

NCERT's framing question: *"Can politics change the clothes people wear, the language they speak or the books they read?"*

Change	Detail
★ Abolition of censorship , summer 1789	Under the Old Regime all written material and cultural activity — books, newspapers, plays — could be published or performed only after approval by the censors of the king . The Declaration made freedom of speech and expression a natural right
The flood of print	Newspapers, pamphlets, books and printed pictures flooded the towns and travelled rapidly into the countryside , describing and discussing events
★★ Freedom of the press cut both ways	It <i>"also meant that</i> opposing views of events could be expressed. Each side sought to convince the others of its position through the medium of print. "*
For the non-reading majority	Plays, songs and festive processions — <i>"one way they could grasp and identify with ideas such as liberty or justice that political philosophers wrote about at length in texts which only a handful of educated people could read"</i>
Festivals	Staged deliberately to mobilise loyalty , using symbols from ancient Greece and Rome to convey <i>"the aura of a hallowed history"</i>
Forms of address	<i>Monsieur/Madame</i> → Citoyen/Citoyenne
Clothing	knee breeches → the <i>sans-culotte's</i> long striped trousers and red cap
Bread	white flour → pain d'égalité

★★ **The transferable insight:** a revolution that only changes the government changes very little. This one went after **the calendar of daily life** — what you eat, what you wear, what you call your neighbour. **Culture is where a political change is either made permanent or lost.**

9 Napoleon and the Legacy

👑 Napoleon

1804	Crowns himself Emperor of France
What he did	Set out to conquer neighbouring European countries , dispossessing dynasties and creating kingdoms where he placed members of his family
His self-image	" <i>Napoleon saw his role as a moderniser of Europe.</i> "
His laws	Protection of private property ; a uniform system of weights and measures provided by the decimal system
The turn	" <i>Initially, many saw Napoleon as a liberator... But soon the Napoleonic armies came to be viewed everywhere as an invading force.</i> "
1815	Defeated at Waterloo
★ The verdict	" <i>Many of his measures that carried the revolutionary ideas of liberty and modern laws to other parts of Europe had an impact on people long after Napoleon had left.</i> "

🌐 The legacy — this is the highest-yield paragraph in the chapter

★★★★★ **"The ideas of liberty and democratic rights were the most important legacy of the French Revolution.** These spread from France to the rest of Europe during the nineteenth century, where **feudal systems were abolished. Colonised peoples reworked the idea of freedom from bondage into their movements to create a sovereign nation state.**"*

And the two Indians NCERT names:

Person	Response
Tipu Sultan	Named as one who responded to the ideas coming from revolutionary France (<i>recall from Class 8 Ch.2 — he had a close relationship with the French in India</i>)
Raja Rammohan Roy	*"He could think and talk of nothing else when he heard of the July Revolution in France in 1830 . On his way to England at Cape Town he insisted on visiting frigates flying the revolutionary tri-colour flag though he had been temporarily lamed by an accident. "* — Susobhan Sarkar, <i>Notes on the Bengal Renaissance</i>

★★★ **This is your bridge sentence between World History and Indian History**, and it is worth memorising the Rammohan Roy image because it is vivid enough to be quoted: a lamed man limping to see a flag.

● Prelims traps

Trap	The truth
"Sans-culottes = without trousers"	Without KNEE BREECHES — long striped trousers instead
"The Bastille was stormed to free hundreds of political prisoners"	It held seven prisoners. It was stormed as a symbol of despotic royal power
"The Estates-General had not met since 1714"	1614 — a gap of 175 years
"Mill's... sorry, the tithe went to the state"	The tithe went to the Church (1/10 of agricultural produce); the taille was the direct tax to the state
"The 1791 Constitution gave universal male suffrage"	Only active citizens — men over 25 paying tax equal to 3 days' wages — about 4 million of 28 million . Universal <i>male</i> suffrage (21+) came only in 1792
"France became a republic in 1789"	21 September 1792 . 1789 = Bastille; 1791 = constitutional monarchy
"Louis XVI was executed in 1792"	21 January 1793 , at the Place de la Concorde
"Slavery was abolished once, in 1794"	1794 abolished → Napoleon reintroduced it (1804) → finally abolished 1848
"Olympe de Gouges wrote the Declaration of the Rights of Man"	She wrote the Declaration of the Rights of Woman and Citizen, 1791
"French women got the vote after the Revolution"	1946
"Rousseau proposed separation of powers"	Montesquieu (<i>The Spirit of the Laws</i>). Rousseau = social contract ; Locke = against divine right
"The Marseillaise was written in Marseilles"	Composed by Roget de L'Isle ; named because volunteers from Marseilles first sang it marching into Paris
"The guillotine was named after its first victim"	After Dr Guillotin, who invented it

● Mains angles

- ★★★★★ "The message of universal rights was beset with contradictions." **Examine.** — The single best question in the chapter. Your four contradictions: **(i)** rights declared universal, but the 1791 Constitution created **active vs passive citizens** on a property test; **(ii)** "Men are born and remain free and equal" — while **women were passive citizens**, their clubs closed and leaders executed; **(iii)** the National Assembly **debated but would not legislate** on colonial slavery "fearing opposition from businessmen", and when abolition came in 1794 it was **reversed within ten years**; **(iv)** **Article 17 made property "sacred and inviolable"**, which is precisely what plantation owners invoked to keep human beings as property.
- ★★★★★ "Terror is nothing but justice, swift, severe and inflexible." **Critically examine revolutionary violence.** — Robespierre vs Desmoulins; note Desmoulins was executed for his answer; end with the Directory and Napoleon as the **cost** of the Terror.
- ★★★★★ **The legacy of the French Revolution for the colonised world.** — Feudalism abolished across Europe; **colonised peoples reworked freedom-from-bondage into sovereign nation-statehood**; Tipu Sultan and Rammohan Roy; and the deep irony that **a France declaring the rights of man was simultaneously running plantations on slave labour** — which is what made the anti-colonial use of these ideas so sharp.
- ★★★★★ "Which groups benefited, which lost, which were disappointed?" — *Benefited*: the **richer third estate** (property, offices, careers open to talent). *Lost*: **clergy and nobility** (tithes abolished, Church

lands confiscated, feudal dues gone, many fled). *Disappointed*: **women**, the **non-propertied poor** (enfranchised 1792, disenfranchised again under the Directory), and **slaves in the colonies** after 1804.

- ★★ ★ **How did a fiscal crisis become a political revolution?** — Debt → the need to tax → the need for consent → the Estates-General → the voting dispute → the claim to represent the nation. **A state that must ask for money must eventually answer to those it asks.**
- ★★ **The rise of Napoleon as an institutional failure, not a personal triumph.**
- ★★ **Print, symbols and festivals as instruments of political mobilisation** — pairs beautifully with the Indian national movement's use of newspapers, songs and processions.

Cross-links to build now

- **Class 8 Ch.2** — Tipu Sultan's French connection is why NCERT can name him here.
 - **Class 8 Ch.7** — Chaumette's "Nature intended it" argument is the same one Indian reformers had to demolish over sati and widow remarriage.
 - **Class 8 Ch.8** — the educated-and-blocked grievance (Danton) is the early Congress's social base; the demand that **civil service exams be held in India** is *careers open to talent* in Indian dress.
 - **Class 10 Ch.1** — nationalism in Europe begins with Napoleon's armies carrying these ideas outward.
 - **Chapter 2 of this book** — Marat's warning is the seed of socialism.
-

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Old Regime	The society and institutions of France before 1789
Estate	One of three orders of French society; the first two enjoyed privileges by birth
Livre	Unit of currency in France, discontinued in 1794
Clergy	Group of persons invested with special functions in the church
Tithe	A tax levied by the Church , comprising one-tenth of the agricultural produce
Taille	Tax to be paid directly to the state
Subsistence crisis	An extreme situation where the basic means of livelihood are endangered
Anonymous	One whose name remains unknown
Château (pl. châteaux)	Castle or stately residence belonging to a king or nobleman
Manor	An estate consisting of the lord's lands and his mansion
Convent	Building belonging to a community devoted to a religious life
Treason	Betrayal of one's country or government
Emancipation	The act of freeing
Active citizen	Man over 25 paying tax equal to 3 days' wages — entitled to vote
Passive citizen	Everyone else — no voting rights
Sans-culottes	" <i>Those without knee breeches</i> " — the radical Jacobin rank and file
Guillotine	Device of two poles and a blade for beheading, named after Dr Guillotin
Pain d'égalité	" <i>Equality bread</i> " — the compulsory wholewheat loaf
Republic	Government where the people elect the government including its head; no hereditary monarchy
Directory	The five-member executive ruling France after the Jacobins fell
Marseillaise	Patriotic song by Roget de L'Isle , now France's national anthem
Fascis	Bundle of rods — symbol that strength lies in unity
Phrygian cap	Red cap worn by a freed slave — symbol of liberty

60-Second Recap

1. **Louis XVI, 1774**, aged 20, married to **Marie Antoinette**, inherits an **empty treasury**; the **American war** adds over **1 billion livres** to a **2 billion+** debt at **10% interest**.
2. **Three estates**. Clergy and nobility are **exempt from tax by birth**; the **third estate alone** pays the **tithe** (Church), **feudal dues** (nobles), the **taille** and indirect taxes (state). **90% are peasants; 60% of land** is owned by nobles, Church and rich commoners.
3. **Population 23 → 28 million** ⇒ grain demand outruns supply ⇒ bread prices rise, wages don't ⇒ **subsistence crisis**: bad harvest → scarcity → price rise → riots → weaker bodies → epidemics → deaths.
4. **The middle class** — merchants, manufacturers, lawyers, officials — has what earlier rebels lacked: **a programme**. Its creed: **no privilege by birth; position by merit**.
5. **Locke** (against divine right) · **Rousseau** (social contract; one man one vote) · **Montesquieu** (separation of powers) · the **American Constitution** as the working example. Spread through **salons, coffee-houses, and reading aloud**.

6. ★ **5 May 1789** Estates-General (first since **1614**); 300+300 seated, **600 stand at the back**; the dispute is **one vote per estate vs per member**. **20 June — Tennis Court Oath**; they become the **National Assembly** under **Mirabeau** and **Abbé Sieyès**.
7. **14 July — the Bastille**, holding **seven** prisoners, is stormed as a **symbol**. The **Great Fear** sweeps the countryside; peasants **burn the records of manorial dues**.
8. ★ **Night of 4 August 1789** — feudal obligations abolished, **tithes abolished**, **Church lands confiscated** (2 billion livres to the state).
9. ★★ **Constitution of 1791** — constitutional monarchy, separation of powers, **indirect election**; only **active citizens** (men 25+, tax = 3 days' wages, **4 of 28 million**) vote; it opens with the **Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen** — "*natural and inalienable*".
10. **April 1792** war on Prussia and Austria; the **Marseillaise**. **Jacobins** under **Robespierre**; the **sans-culottes**. **10 August** — the Tuileries stormed; **all men 21+ get the vote**.
11. ★ **21 September 1792** — **monarchy abolished**, **France a republic**. **21 January 1793** — **Louis XVI executed** for treason.
12. **1793–94 Reign of Terror** — guillotine, price and wage ceilings, rationing, **pain d'égalité**, **Citoyen/Citoyenne**, churches shut. "*Terror is nothing but justice*." **Robespierre guillotined July 1794**.
13. **The Directory** — five-member executive, vote taken back from the non-propertied; its **instability produces Napoleon**.
14. **Women: ~60 clubs**, the **Society of Revolutionary and Republican Women**, the **October 1789 march to Versailles**; won **compulsory schooling for girls**, **marriage as free contract**, **legal divorce**, **training for jobs**; but remained **passive citizens**, clubs **closed in 1793**, **Olympe de Gouges** (*Declaration of the Rights of Woman*, 1791) **executed**. **French women voted only in 1946**.
15. **Slavery**: triangular trade from **Bordeaux/Nantes**; **little criticism through the 18th century**; the Assembly **debated but did not act**; **the Convention abolished it in 1794**; **Napoleon reintroduced it**; **finally abolished 1848**.
16. **Everyday life: censorship abolished 1789**, print flooded the country, **opposing views could now be printed**, and plays, songs and festivals carried the ideas to the illiterate.
17. **Napoleon: emperor 1804, moderniser and invader, defeated at Waterloo 1815**. Legacy = **liberty and democratic rights**; feudalism swept from Europe; **colonised peoples reworked freedom from bondage into the demand for a sovereign nation state** — **Tipu Sultan** and **Rammohan Roy**.

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Which of the following taxes was paid by the third estate to the **Church**? — The **tithe**, one-tenth of agricultural produce. The **taille** was the direct tax to the state.
2. Arrange in order: (a) Tennis Court Oath (b) Storming of the Bastille (c) Convocation of the Estates-General (d) Abolition of the feudal system. — **c (5 May) → a (20 June) → b (14 July) → d (4 August)**, all in 1789.
3. Under the Constitution of 1791, an "active citizen" was — **a man above 25 paying taxes equal to at least 3 days of a labourer's wage; about 4 million of a population of 28 million**.
4. *The Spirit of the Laws* proposed — the **division of power** between legislature, executive and judiciary — **Montesquieu**; the model was put into force in the **USA**.
5. Consider: (i) France was declared a republic in September 1792. (ii) Louis XVI was executed in January 1793. (iii) Slavery in French colonies was abolished in 1794 and remained abolished. — **(i) and (ii) only**. **Napoleon reintroduced slavery; final abolition was 1848**.

6. Olympe de Gouges is associated with — *the **Declaration of the Rights of Woman and Citizen (1791)**; she was charged with **treason** and executed in **1793**.*
7. The *sans-culottes* were so called because they — wore **long striped trousers instead of knee breeches**, marking themselves off from the nobility.

Mains style

8. "The message of universal rights was beset with contradictions." Explain. **(250 words)** — ★ the flagship question of this chapter
9. Describe the circumstances leading to the outbreak of revolutionary protest in France. **(150 words)**
10. Which groups of French society benefited from the revolution, which were forced to relinquish power, and which would have been disappointed with its outcome? **(250 words)**
11. Describe the legacy of the French Revolution for the peoples of the world during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. **(250 words)**
12. "In time of Revolution a democratic government may rely on terror." Critically examine Robespierre's claim in the light of the Reign of Terror and its aftermath. **(250 words)**
13. How would you explain the rise of Napoleon? **(150 words)**
14. Draw up a list of democratic rights we enjoy today whose origins can be traced to the French Revolution. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Name the three estates, and say who paid the tithe, the taille and feudal dues.
- Give the four dates of 1789 in order, with what happened on each.
- Define an active citizen and a passive citizen, with the numbers.
- Quote Articles 1, 3 and 17 of the Declaration.
- Give Robespierre's justification of terror and Desmoulins' reply.
- List four gains women made and three things they were denied.
- Give the three dates of slavery: abolished, reintroduced, finally abolished.
- Explain why the Directory produced Napoleon.